

I HAVE BEEN HERE THREE TIMES

First when I was young and angry. I left my father's shield. I asked Mars for victory.

Second time I was less young. I left my husband's shield. I asked Mars to keep what was left.

This is the third time. I brought my son's shield. He has a Roman name now. He works the roads. He sends money home. It is a good life, he says.

I do not blame him.

I left his shield here anyway. Let Mars decide what that means.

We are Suebi. We do not stop. That is not a boast — it is just true. We have been here longer than Rome's name for us. We will be here when they have run out of things to call us.

The serpent coils here while the people move.

I will not come back a fourth time.

But someone will.